

What type of data collection should you use when evaluating an organization, provider, policy or initiative?

Evaluation planners often start from scratch when trying to identify the types of data collection they will use in a particular evaluation. To do this successfully, they need to remember a comprehensive list of all of the different evaluation data collection methods that they could potentially use. A wide range of people are involved in aspects of evaluation planning. Not all of them have memorized a comprehensive list of evaluation data collection types. And even if they do, different people may use different terms for the same type of data collection type.

A way of ensuring that all types of data collection have been considered and that a common set of terms is being used to describe them is to use this Evaluation Data Collection Types Tool (G16) to review the possible data collection types for use in evaluations.

This tool identifies a list of different data collection types, ranging from 'directly observing' through to 'measuring indicators'. It identifies the sub-types within these, e.g. for 'directly observing', there is 'participant' and 'non-participant'. Following this, the source, such as 'participants' or 'key informants' is identified. The tool also sets out the mode of data collection, e.g. 'face-to-face' or 'online/phone'. And it outlines the analysis method from 'qualitative' analysis through to 'grounded theory'.

The purpose of this tool is to provide a standard terminology for describing evaluation data collection types that can be used within evaluation planning and commissioning. In addition, this Evaluation Data Collection Types Tool (G15) can be provided to evaluators when they are asked to submit evaluation proposals. Then such evaluators submitting evaluation proposals can use the same terms to describe the data collection types they are proposing to use within their evaluations. This puts evaluation commissioners in a better position to be able to compare different evaluation proposals because common terminology is being used.